



MCKENZIE RIVER VALLEY · BUYING A HOME · FALL 2026

Buying up *river*, start to keys

Buying out here is not like buying in town: wells, flood maps, septic systems and shared gravel roads all decide what a place is worth, and this guide takes you through them in the order you will meet them, from the first lender call to the day you get the keys.



10

BUSINESS DAYS A BUYER TYPICALLY HAS TO INSPECT

30-45

DAYS FROM ACCEPTED OFFER TO CLOSING ON A TYPICAL FINANCED PURCHASE

0%

DOWN ON A USDA LOAN FOR AN ELIGIBLE RURAL HOME



01 · WELCOME

I work the river I *live* on

I live in the McKenzie Valley, and I fish it whenever the work lets me. My practice is the corridor between Springfield and McKenzie Bridge: Thurston, Cedar Flat, Walterville, Deerhorn, Leaburg, Vida, Nimrod, Finn Rock, Blue River, Rainbow and McKenzie Bridge, plus Eugene, Camp Creek and the Mohawk Valley over the ridge. One river, and every mile of it different from the last.

That is why I wrote this. Most buying guides are written for town, where the water comes from the city and the road belongs to the county. Up river, what decides a property's value is usually what you cannot see from the driveway: the well, the septic, the flood map, the bank, the easement. I would rather you read about them here than meet them in week three of a contract.

You get me on every call, with The Operative Group behind me on the transaction work and a second set of eyes on every negotiation. Read this in order, write in the margins, and text me when something does not add up.

George Winters · Broker · Real Broker LLC





Eight steps, *one* at a time

1. **Call a lender.** Before you tour, find out what you can borrow and what monthly payment you can live with. Tell them if you are looking at river, acreage or a manufactured home. It changes which loans fit.
2. **Sign a buyer agreement with me.** Oregon requires one in writing. It says what I do and how I get paid (sections 04 and 05).
3. **Decide what you are buying.** Frontage, a river view, acreage or a town lot. Each one shops and inspects differently.
4. **Tour with a purpose.** Fewer showings, better chosen, with the systems looked at as we go.
5. **Write the offer.** Price from sales I have walked, with terms and protections that fit the property.
6. **Offer accepted.** Earnest money goes to the title company and the inspection clock starts. We book the well, septic and other specialists that same day.
7. **Inspect and negotiate.** The house, the water, the septic, the wood stove, and the river where it applies.
8. **Appraisal, final approval, keys.** The lender confirms the value, we walk through one last time, you sign, and the deed records.

Every one of those steps has a date in your contract. I keep the calendar so you can keep your head.

Text 541-870-8378 to start →



PART ONE

Money and *footing*

The lender, the agreement and the budget. Get these settled before you fall for a stretch of river.





03 · WHAT I DO FOR YOU

On your side of the *table*

Hire me to help you buy and Oregon law gives you more than my good intentions. I owe you real duties: loyalty (I work for you, not the seller), care and skill (I tell you what I see, flaws included), confidentiality (your top number and your timing stay with me), disclosure (if I learn something that matters, you hear it), and accounting (your money and documents get handled right and on time). Before we start you also get Oregon's initial agency disclosure pamphlet, which sets this out in the state's own words.

STAGE

MY PART

Before you tour	Pulling well logs, flood zones and septic permits, so we skip places that will not pass
On the property	Reading the bank, the water and the systems with you, and checking the cell signal in the driveway
The offer	Pricing from comps I have walked, with protections that fit rural property
Under contract	Booking specialists the day you are accepted, tracking every deadline, negotiating what they find
After keys	The contractor, well driller and firewood names you will need next

04 · THE BUYER AGREEMENT

Put it in *writing*

Oregon requires a written agreement between a buyer and the broker helping them. Mine is short. It covers what I will do and for how long, where you are looking (or the one property, if that is all it covers), how I am paid and by whom, and how either of us can end it.

Read every line before you sign. If something in it surprises you, we talk about it first.

Ask me to walk you through it →



05 • HOW I GET PAID

The money, *plainly*

Since August 2024, a buyer's broker's pay is no longer posted on the MLS. You and I agree on it in writing before we start. Then, place by place, we find out what the seller will put toward it. Many sellers still cover it, and we can ask in the offer. If one offers less or nothing, we decide together: ask for a concession, adjust the price, or cover the gap. Either way you know before you sign, and nothing leaves your pocket that is not on paper.

06 • THE FULL BUDGET

Plan past the *payment*

The price is the big number. Out here, a handful of smaller ones ride along with it.

COST	WHEN	WHAT TO EXPECT
Earnest money	A few days after acceptance	Often around 1% of the price. The title company holds it and credits it back at closing
Inspections	Inspection period	The house, plus the well, septic and chimney. Separate bills, each one worth it
Flood quote and elevation certificate	Before you offer	A quote costs nothing. A certificate is a surveyor's fee and can cut the premium for years
Survey	When the line matters	Quoted locally. Worth it on land, or where a boundary decides the value
Appraisal	After inspections	Ordered by your lender
Down payment	At closing	Anywhere from 0% to 20% or more, set by the loan
Closing costs	At closing	Lender, escrow, recording, title, prepaid taxes and insurance. Your Loan Estimate has the figures
Getting set up	First few months	Firewood, a generator, tools, and whatever the inspector said could wait



Oregon property tax is based on assessed value, which usually grows no more than 3% a year, not on what the place would sell for. The bill comes in October, and paying the whole year by November 15 takes 3% off. Keep a cushion past closing day, too. A rural house will ask for something in the first month.

07 · PRE-APPROVAL

Get your number *first*

Pre-qualification is a conversation. Pre-approval means a lender has gone through your income, credit and savings, and sellers treat it that way. The lender will want pay stubs and two years of W-2s or tax returns (business returns and a current profit and loss if you work for yourself), recent bank and retirement statements, where the down payment comes from, a photo ID and a credit pull. Gift money, a divorce or a new job: say so on day one, not in week four.

Ask every lender: What is my full monthly payment? How much cash at closing? Which loans fit me, and why? What can I lock, for how long, at what cost? And the one that matters up river: *have you closed loans on well and septic, river or acreage property?*

08 · LOAN OPTIONS

The loans buyers here *use*

LOAN	MINIMUM DOWN	WORTH KNOWING
Conventional	3% for many first-time buyers, 5% otherwise	Under 20% down you pay mortgage insurance, which can be removed later
FHA	3.5% with a 580+ credit score	Gentler on credit, with mortgage insurance up front and monthly
VA	0% for eligible veterans and service members	No monthly mortgage insurance. A funding fee, unless you are exempt
USDA	0%	Eligible rural areas and buyers under the income limits. Much of the corridor east of Springfield qualifies. The lender checks the exact address



LOAN	MINIMUM DOWN	WORTH KNOWING
Oregon Bond loan	Low, with down payment help available	Oregon Housing and Community Services, for first-time buyers or anyone who has not owned in three years, under income and price limits
FHA 203(k)	3.5%	Buys the place and funds the repairs in one loan

Rules and limits move. This table starts the conversation; a lender finishes it. If you are a first-time buyer, ask about Oregon's assistance programs, and take the homebuyer education class early. Many programs require it, it costs little or nothing, and it is easier done before you need the certificate.



09 · RURAL AND RIVER LOANS

Where lenders get *picky*

Unusual property meets cautious underwriting. None of this kills a sale, but each one is easier found early.

- **The appraisal.** The nearest comparable sale might be three miles off and nothing like your place, and the appraiser may come from out of the area. I send them context on the comps.
- **Land and outbuildings.** Lenders look at how much of the value is land, and how to count a shop or barn. Ask before you tour 20 acres.
- **Water and septic.** Some lenders want a flow number, a clean water test, or a recorded agreement on a shared well.
- **Private roads.** Some ask how a shared road is kept up. A recorded maintenance agreement answers it.
- **Manufactured homes.** The title should be retired into the real property, with foundation and installation records. Age matters to many programs.
- **Flood zones.** In a high-risk zone, a federally backed loan requires flood insurance, and the premium counts in your payment.

Five minutes with a lender about the property type saves five weeks later. I know lenders who close river and acreage loans all the time.

[Ask me for a name →](#)



PART TWO

The river and the *ground*

What makes buying on this corridor different, and the checks that turn a pretty place into a known one.





Choose your *mile*

Highway 126 is the one road up the valley, and where you land on it sets your drive, your systems and your winters. Most regret I see is not the wrong valley. It is the wrong mile.

STRETCH	FROM SPRINGFIELD	WHAT YOU USUALLY FIND
Springfield and Thurston	In town	City water and sewer on most lots, with wells and septic on the eastern edge
Cedar Flat and Waltherville	About 10 minutes	Small acreage, the first wells and septic, Hendricks Bridge launch, some mapped floodplain
Deerhorn and Leaburg	15 to 20 minutes	Quiet south-bank lanes, flat water at Leaburg Lake, cabins and riverfront homes
Vida	About 30 minutes	The Goodpasture covered bridge, older cabins next to homes built since 2020
Nimrod and Finn Rock	35 to 40-plus minutes	Bigger parcels, longer frontage, popular launches
Blue River and Rainbow	About 45 minutes	The upper valley hub, two reservoirs, rebuilt homes, big timber
McKenzie Bridge	About an hour	Forest-edge cabins near the falls, the trail and the hot springs. Real winter
Eugene	20 minutes to Thurston	The city end, where a lot of corridor buyers start

Name what you are buying. Frontage means you own to the water: the most homework, the highest price. A view trades the waterline for height, often with more sun and simpler paperwork. Access means a launch nearby, and the savings can buy the boat. Tell me which before we tour. This valley is full of frontage owners who wanted a view, and the other way round.



Buy the bank, not just the *view*

Frontage is the scarcest thing in this valley, so it gets the most homework.

- **The flood zone.** FEMA zones starting with A are high risk, and a federally backed loan there requires flood insurance. Zones like X usually leave it up to you. The premium turns on how high the house sits, so an **elevation certificate** can matter a lot: a house that sits above the mapped flood level can price far better, and may support a Letter of Map Amendment. We look up the zone and get a quote before you write.
- **Setbacks and the riparian strip.** Ground along the water has its own rules: setbacks for new buildings, county review for work near the bank, limits on clearing native plants. Your building area may be smaller than the acreage says. An existing house is usually fine as built; the rules bite when you add on or rebuild.
- **Bank work.** The county reviews the riparian zone, the state's removal-fill program covers work at and below the waterline, and federal agencies can be involved in the channel. If there is riprap, we ask what permits stand behind it.
- **Erosion.** Outside bends take the river's force; inside bends collect gravel. Established trees mean a bank that has seen many winters. A raw cut and leaning trees mean it is moving. Home policies generally do not cover ground that moves, so we read the bank first.

"Room for a dock" is a hope until the county and the state say otherwise. We find out before it ends up in your price.

Walk a bank with me →



Know what comes out of the *tap*

Outside city limits, almost every place here runs on its own water.

- **The well log.** The state keeps a construction report for most wells: when, how deep, how it was sealed, and the flow on the day it was drilled. I pull it. No log means we lean harder on today's testing.
- **The state test at sale.** Oregon requires the seller of a property with a domestic well to test it for arsenic, nitrates and total coliform bacteria and report the results to the state. We check it was done properly and recently, and add tests like lead, iron or manganese when the house calls for them. None of these have a taste.
- **A flow test.** A real one draws the well down for hours and measures what it can sustain. A running faucet is not a flow test, and late summer is when a well tells the truth. A modest well feeding storage tanks runs a normal house all over this valley.
- **Pump, tank and wellhead.** The parts that actually wear out.
- **Shared wells.** The recorded agreement on costs, repairs and access is what you are really buying.
- **Water rights.** Oregon's water belongs to the public. A household well generally runs under an exemption with limits. Irrigating from the river usually needs a water right. "Water rights included" means we check the state record, because a right can be lost through non-use.
- **Springs.** Whether a spring needs a water right depends on how it flows. We check, and we test the water like a well.



What sits under the *gravel*

Septic. Inspect it every time. A real inspection pumps the tank, checks the baffles and lines, looks at the drainfield and maps it all. The drainfield is the expensive part, and you cannot judge it from the lawn. The county permit says how many bedrooms the system was approved for. A four-bedroom listing on a two-bedroom permit gets raised before closing.

Access. Legal access is public road frontage or an easement recorded in the title. A driveway the neighbors have put up with for thirty years does not count. We also read the easement: width, uses, upkeep, and whether utilities can use it.

Private roads. Many lanes up river are private. A recorded road maintenance agreement says who pays for gravel, grading and culverts, and it binds the next neighbor too. Without one, the road runs on goodwill. That can work, and we price it.

Zoning. Much of rural Lane County is farm or forest zoning, where a house is allowed only through specific paths. If you plan to build, add a dwelling or run a business, county planning gets the first call.

Bare land. Before you pay homesite money, a parcel has to prove itself: an approved septic site evaluation, water prospects from the neighbors' well logs, a real power quote, and a driveway that sheds water. And where the line matters, pay the surveyor before you pay the seller. Old fences wander.



Fire, wood and *winter*

Wildfire. The 2020 Holiday Farm Fire burned through parts of this corridor and hit Blue River hard. Those communities have been rebuilding since, and homes built to current code now stand beside cabins that came through. On any parcel we look at the history plainly: what burned, what was rebuilt with permits, whether the well and septic survived, and which trees are hazards.

Defensible space and insurance. Keep the ground right around the house lean, thin fuels farther out, and harden what embers find: roof, vents, decks. Sign up for county emergency alerts. Insurers look at each property's setting and what has been done to protect it, so quote early and keep the receipts.

Wood heat. Most of the valley burns wood. Oregon requires certain older uncertified stoves to be removed and destroyed when a home sells, so we confirm what the house has, get the chimney inspected, and tell your insurer up front.

Internet and cell. Service changes mile to mile. Stand in the driveway with your own phone, run a speed test, and ask the neighbors what they use. Satellite has changed what is possible up top. If you work from home, plan a backup.

Winter on Highway 126. The highway is maintained, and storm days still come. Up river you keep good tires, a generator tested in the fall, insulated pipes and some slack in the calendar. Outages are a when, not an if.



See it in the *rain*

- **Tell me how you will live there.** The commute, the shop, the boat, the garden, the animals, the home office.
- **Drive your real commute** at your real hours before you commit to the upper valley.
- **Come in winter if you can.** Drift lines on the bank, standing water, a steep driveway in the wet.
- **Check your bars** in the driveway and at the corners of the house.
- **Bring me in early.** Before you ring the number on a yard sign or walk into a builder's model, text me. Builders often want your broker registered on the first visit.
- **Price the expensive things,** not the paint: roof, water, heat, drainage and the road in.
- **Buying from a distance?** My video tours show the flaws first: the crawlspace, the panel, the well house, the bank.

More than a *number*

We set the price from sales I have walked, not an online estimate. Then the earnest money, your financing, the contingencies (inspection, financing, appraisal, the sale of your home if you need it, and a feasibility period on bare land), the dates, and what stays: the generator, the woodpile, the tractor. If it matters to you, it goes in writing.

When others want the same place, sellers weigh certainty as much as price. A strong pre-approval, dates that suit the seller, and a tighter inspection schedule with specialists already lined up often beat a bigger number. We set your ceiling while you are calm, and we stop there.

Before you give up any protection, I will tell you in dollars what it could cost you.

[Talk an offer through →](#)



PART THREE

From yes to the *keys*

The weeks between an accepted offer and closing day. Up river, the specialists and the calendar decide most of it.





17 · OFFER ACCEPTED

The first *week*

The signed contract goes to the title company. Oregon closes through escrow: a neutral company holds the money, clears title and records the deed.

1. **Earnest money.** It reaches the title company within a few business days and counts toward your purchase. Your contingencies protect it. Back out for a reason the contract does not cover, and you can lose it.
2. **The seller's disclosure.** Oregon gives you five business days from receiving the seller's property disclosure statement to revoke your offer, unless you waived that right. On rural property I read it for the well, septic, water rights, easements, fire history and outbuilding permits.
3. **Specialists booked that day.** Well testers, septic inspectors and chimney sweeps book out, labs take days, and your deadline does not move.

18 · INSPECTIONS

The rural *stack*

The inspection period is often 10 business days. In town one inspection covers most of it. Up river it is the start.

INSPECTION

WHAT IT TELLS YOU

Home	Structure, roof, electrical, plumbing, heating. Hire thorough, not fast
Well	Log, flow test, water panel, pump, pressure tank, wellhead
Septic	Pumped, scoped and mapped, permit matched to bedrooms
Wood heat	Stove certification, chimney, clearances
Outbuildings	Structure and wiring in the shop or barn
River	Flood documents, a read of the bank, insurance quotes
As needed	Sewer scope on city lots, radon, pest, roof, hazard trees



Come along if you can: an hour beside the inspector teaches more than the report. Then we go through the findings together and sort the serious from the normal for an older rural house. You can ask for repairs, a credit or a lower price, take it as it is, or step away inside the contract's terms. Whatever we agree with the seller goes in writing before the period runs out.

A general inspector flags. A specialist verifies. On the well and the septic,
I want the specialist every time.

Ask what this place needs →

19 · TITLE, INSURANCE AND APPRAISAL

Paper that *protects* you

- **Title.** The title company searches the public record for liens, easements and anything else attached to the land, and sends a preliminary report. On rural property, this is where we confirm your access and find easements across your ground. In Oregon the seller usually buys your owner's title policy; your lender needs its own.
- **Survey.** Title says what you own. A survey shows where it is.
- **Homeowner's insurance.** The lender needs it bound before closing. Start early on wooded, riverside or wood-heated homes, where quotes swing. Flood is a separate policy.
- **Home warranty.** Optional first-year cover for systems and appliances. Sellers sometimes pay for one.

The appraisal checks the price against value. With thin comps up river, I give the appraiser the context.

APPRAISED VALUE

YOUR OPTIONS

Matches or beats the price

Nothing changes. The loan keeps moving

Comes in short

The seller drops the price, you cover the gap, you split it, or we ask for a second look with stronger comps

Comes in well short and
nobody budges

An appraisal or financing contingency may let you cancel and get your earnest money back



Walkthrough, wire, *keys*

- **Hold still.** Until the loan funds: no new credit, no job change, no big unexplained transfers, and leave the savings your lender counted alone.
- **The final walkthrough.** A day or two out, we go back. Repairs done? Woodpile still there? Run the taps and listen for the pump.
- **Your closing statement** arrives a few days ahead, and we read it together, every line.
- **Wiring money.** Get the title company's number from a source you trust, and call it before a dollar moves. Email and text instructions are where the thieves live.
- **Signing.** At the title company, usually a day or two before closing. From out of state, remote signing is routine; we arrange it early.
- **Recording.** The county records the deed, the funds release, and the place is yours on the possession date in your contract.

Wire fraud goes after buyers in the last week. If wiring instructions ever change, stop and call me.

Save my number: 541-870-8378 →



Straight *answers*

Do all riverfront homes need flood insurance? No. Plenty sit above the mapped zones. It depends on the zone and your lender, and the cost depends on how high the house sits. That is why we quote it before you write.

Can I put stairs or a dock down the bank? Maybe. Work near the water goes through the county, the state and sometimes federal agencies, and docks are less common here than on a lake. We find out for that bank first.

Can I clear the trees along my bank for a better view? Clearing in the riparian strip is regulated. A permitted view path is often possible. Taking it all down is not. Ask the county before the chainsaw.

Does my well need a water right? An ordinary household well generally runs under an exemption with limits. Watering big pasture or pumping from the river is different. We check which side your plans fall on.

The seller says access has never been a problem. Enough? No. That is a story, not a recorded right. The title report answers it.

Can I work from home in the upper valley? Many people do. Test at the address, not the town name, and set up a backup.

Is a fire-affected parcel a bad buy? Not by itself. It is priced for its condition. We check hazard trees, soils, whether the well and septic survived, and what was rebuilt with permits, then decide on facts.



22 · YOUR WISHLIST

What you are really *after*

Fill this in before we sit down. Ten minutes here saves us an afternoon of the wrong showings.

Must have

Would love

Deal breakers

Frontage, view, access, or none

Stretch of the corridor I want

Where I drive most, and how often

Land, shop, animals or garden

Internet I need for work

Wood heat: yes, no, or happy to learn

Monthly payment I'm comfortable with

When I want to move



Three things this *week*

1. **Call a lender** and get pre-approved. Tell them what kind of property you are after.
2. **Fill in the wishlist** on the page before this one.
3. **Text me.** We sit down for half an hour, or drive up the river together for an afternoon. Then I set up a search that catches the right places the day they list.

That first talk costs you nothing and commits you to nothing. Ask me anything. You will get a straight answer, and you set the pace from there.

Text 541-870-8378, or find me at mckenzieriverrealestate.com. I am a broker with Real Broker LLC, Oregon licence 201251081, and part of The Operative Group: a full team on the transaction, and me on the phone.

